

DECISIVE MOMENT November 1, 1755 10:00 am

# Lisbon Earthquake

**The Lisbon earthquake was the one of the worst natural disasters in European history. Up to 100,000 people perished in the earthquake itself and in the tsunami and fire that followed. The physical shockwaves were felt around the world; but the event also caused people to question established beliefs.**

In the 18th century, Lisbon, situated on the southwest coast of Portugal, at the mouth of the Tagus River, was a grand, affluent city that formed the hub of a vast global empire. But by 10:00 am on November 1, 1755, an earthquake measuring an estimated 9 on the Richter scale (the highest number on the scale being 10) had reduced Lisbon to a scene of utter devastation. Cracks as wide as 16 ft (5 m) appeared in the ground, swallowing buildings and people.

In panic, many inhabitants had fled toward the port at the mouth of the river, clambering aboard the ships moored there in the belief that they would be in a safer place. But the earthquake was followed by a massive tsunami, a huge wall of water some 20 ft (6 m) high, that crashed into the city and roared up the river, causing further death and destruction. All along the coast of Portugal, towns were inundated by catastrophic floods. Agadir in North Africa was flooded, leaving thousands dead, and the wave traveled as far as northern Europe and across the Atlantic as far as Barbados. Once the ground had

stopped shaking and the waters had receded, the third disaster, fire, struck Lisbon. The flames continued to burn for six days. These three catastrophes resulted in the destruction of three-quarters of Lisbon's buildings, including the city's vast royal library, which held priceless works of art and historical records detailing Portuguese expeditions to Southeast Asia.

The earthquake had struck on All Saints' Day, one of the holiest days in the Christian calendar. Priests saw the timing as an indication that God was punishing people. The earthquake caused others to question the very existence of a higher being. The event became a key topic of discussion for thinkers of the Enlightenment (see pp.270–71), who began to look for the causes of such disasters in the natural world, rather than blaming the wrath of God. The French writer and philosopher Voltaire used the earthquake to attack blind faith in God; while the German philosopher Immanuel Kant argued that the causes of the disaster should be examined scientifically, and that it is the responsibility of humanity to prepare itself for such events.

## Disaster strikes

As the earthquake struck, Lisbon's buildings rocked backward and forward. Ships were torn from their anchorages and buildings collapsed, killing most of the people inside.

“I assure you this **once opulent city** is nothing but **ruins...**”

REVEREND CHARLES DAVY, AN EYEWITNESS, 1755

